

MELA MELEE Anxious relatives rifle through scattered belongings at the stampede site

beneath the onslaught of the rush.

Seventeen hours later, Mela Officer Vijay Kiran Anand and DIG Vaibhav Krishna held a brief three-minute press briefing. "30 devotees lost. 60 injured. 25 identified," they told the attendees. "*Jo shraddhalu kai baar zameen pe so jaate hain ya wait karte hain brahm muhurat ka, unke upar doosre shraddhalu afra tafri mein chadh gaye...* (The devotees who often go off to sleep on the ground or those who wait for the *brahma muhurta* were trampled upon by others)," DIG Krishna explained. That was not enough to stop the flood of questions. Why did the crowd spiral out of control to begin with?

Stampedes at religious gatherings in India are nothing new—Haridwar, 2010; Allahabad railway station, 2013; Mumbai's Elphinstone Bridge, 2017. But the lessons are never learnt.

This was touted as a Mahakumbh where 'AI meets Ancient India'. And the government could not stop flaunting it—fromAI-powered crowd density monitoring, an AI chatbot, CCTV cameras and drones for aerial surveillance, underwater drones, facial recognition technology at entry points to a dedicated app for real-time updates on crowd density and emergency alerts to manage the 1 billion visitors expected.

LESSONS NOT LEARNT

- **No centralised planning. Same entry and exit points on roads**
- **Pontoon bridges closed randomly, forcing people into bottlenecks**
- **Crowd concentrated on Sangam Nose, which again had the same entry and exit point**
- **VIP movement left ordinary attendees stranded behind barricades**

But what the authorities forgot is that crowd management is a science—a meticulous balance of space, movement and access. It requires clear pathways, separate entry and exit points, real-time monitoring and immediate intervention when pressure builds.

Instead, as 27-year-old Prayagraj resident Shikha Pandey, a regular visitor to the Kumbh, told INDIA TODAY, "There was no proper planning. The authorities themselves seemed unsure where to regulate the crowd and where to allow movement. They were making decisions on the spot. Their only response to congestion was to put up barricades."

That mismanagement extended to pontoon bridges. The administration had boasted of 30 floating bridges connecting the three landmasses of the Kumbh Mela area. But as it turned out, these became zones of disaster in themselves. The officials would often direct people toward a particular pontoon bridge, only for them to reach and find it closed. Lakhs of devotees were thus caught in bottlenecks. Also, as Pandey points out, unlike in 2019, when the entry and exit routes were separate, the authorities this time seemed overconfident about the wider roads—a hundred-odd had been renovated or beautified—allowing movement from both directions, creating bottlenecks.

Ditto for the pathways leading in and out of the Sangam Nose, making retreat impossible. Pandey criticises the administration's failure to convince pilgrims that taking a dip at the Sangam Nose was not mandatory—that they could bathe at any of the 44 designated ghats spread across 12 kilometres. Announcements urging people to use other ghats came too late, by which time the crowd had already surged toward the small, overcrowded Sangam Nose.

The VIP culture was another sore point with many attendees. The roads, designed to carry the faithful, were frequently shut down for politicians, bureaucrats and special guests. Whenever a VIP convoy passed, barriers went up, vehicles got rerouted and common devotees were left stranded.

Even as the authorities scrambled to manage the fallout of the midnight stampede, many claim that another stampede struck just four hours later, at 6 am, two kilometres away in Jhunsi. But it went unacknowledged—admitting to back-to-back stampedes, authorities feared, would only incite further panic among the crores still waiting for a holy dip.

The ripples of the disaster were felt beyond the immediate loss of life. The Prayagraj Hotel and Restaurant Welfare Association reported mass cancellations, with figures dipping as low as 30-35 per cent through February. The crowds, too, thinned dramatically. If nearly 80 million took a holy dip on January 29, the numbers had dropped to 20.5 million by Basant Panchami on February 3. "The excitement has faded," says Pandey. "Maybe people are scared."

To reassure them, the Yogi Adityanath government sprung into immediate action. It set up a three-member commission led by retired high court judge Justice Harsh Kumar to submit a report within a month. The government also declared that no VIP protocols would be enforced during upcoming major *snan*s. Senior officials visited Prayagraj to reassess and strengthen crowd management strategies. Financial aid of Rs 25 lakh was announced for the families of the deceased. They had gone to the Sangam to seek rebirth. Little did they know it would become their final resting place. ■